Name: _____ Date: _____

TOOLKIT Your Problem-Solving Phrasal Verbs

Six verbs for when life doesn't go as planned

figure out

understand / find the answer

"I couldn't figure out the new app."

SPLITS → figure it out

come up with

think of (an idea, a plan)

"We came up with a plan."

NEVER SPLITS → come up with it

give up

stop trying · stop a habit

"Don't give up!" · "I gave up sugar."

SPLITS → give it up · give up + -ing

start over

begin again from the beginning

"The site crashed, so I had to start over."

NO OBJECT → I had to start over.

sort out

fix / resolve a problem; organize

"I sorted out my phone bill."

SPLITS → sort it out

work out

exercise · end well · plan details · fix a problem between people

"Don't worry. It'll work out."

SPLITS (with object) → work it out

The Pronoun Rule

With a **noun**, both are OK:	✔ figure out the problem ✔ figure the problem out
With a **pronoun** (it, them, him, her), it **must** go in the middle:	✔ figure it out ✘ figure out it
come up with never splits:	✔ come up with it ✘ come it up with

Say It Like an American

The words connect. The **t** sounds like a soft **d**.

figure it out → *figyer-i-DOUT*

sort it out → *sor-di-DOUT*

give it up → *gi-vi-DUP*

work it out → *wor-ki-DOUT*

EXERCISE 1 What Happened? Read the Story, Complete the Sentence

Use the correct form (past tense!)

figure out · come up with · give up · start over · sort out · work out

1. Maya's laptop wouldn't turn on. She tried three things. Then she saw the cable was loose.
   → She finally _____ it _____.
2. It was raining, and the kids were bored. Omar had an idea: a picnic on the living room floor.
   → He _____ a fun idea.
3. Ana took guitar lessons for one month. Then she stopped. "It's too hard," she said.
   → She _____.
4. Carlos was on page 4 of a long online form. The page froze and deleted everything.
   → He had to _____.
5. Linh's internet bill was $40 too high. She called the company, and they fixed it in ten minutes.
   → They _____ it _____ in ten minutes.
6. Ravi and his roommate argued about cleaning. They talked and made a schedule together.
   → They _____ it _____ together.

EXERCISE 2 Pronoun Swap

*Change the underlined words to **it** or **them**. Careful — one verb never splits!*

1. I can't figure out this map.
   → _____
2. Please don't give up your dream.
   → _____
3. The manager sorted out the problems.
   → _____
4. We worked out the details.
   → _____
5. She came up with the idea.
   → _____
6. Can you figure out the password?
   → _____

EXERCISE 3 One Verb, Four Meanings: *work out*

Write the letter of the meaning.

A exercise	**B** end well / have a good result
C plan the details	**D** fix a problem between people

1. I work out at the Y three times a week. _____
2. My first apartment didn't work out, but the second one is great. _____
3. We still need to work out who's driving on Saturday. _____
4. You two had a fight? Talk to each other. You'll work it out. _____
5. Don't worry. Everything will work out. _____
6. My sister works out at 5:30 a.m. before work! _____

💡 In American English, for "understand / solve," most people say **figure out**: "I can't figure out this map."

EXERCISE 4 Error Detective

Some sentences are correct!

Write ✔ if the sentence is correct. If it is wrong, fix it.

Sentence	✔ / ✘	Fix (if needed)
1. I finally figured out it.		
2. She came up with a great plan.		
3. Don't give up! You're almost there.		
4. He gave up to smoke last year.		
5. My computer crashed, so I had to start over.		
6. We need to sort out it before Friday.		
7. They came a solution up with.		
8. Can you figure out how to turn it on?		

EXERCISE 5 Text Message Rescue

Complete the text thread

figure it out · **sort it out** · **give up** · **came up with** · **start over** · **worked out**

Jordan Hey! Are you still coming tonight? 🎉

Mai Ugh, I don't know. My car won't start and I can't (1) _____.

Jordan Oh no! Did you call your brother? He knows cars.

Mai Yeah, he's coming tomorrow to (2) _____.

Jordan OK, don't (3) _____ on tonight! I (4) _____ a plan: I'll pick you up at 7.

Mai You're the best. Also, I finished my long application... then the website crashed and I had to (5) _____ 😩

Jordan Noooo. Well, at least the plan for tonight (6) _____! See you at 7.

EXERCISE 6 Spoken or Written? Would You Say This?

Register check

Part A. *Phrasal verbs are great for speaking. Match each one to a more formal word.*

1. figure out		a. resolve
2. come up with		b. begin again
3. give up		c. determine / understand
4. sort out		d. develop / create
5. start over		e. quit / stop

Part B. *Which sounds more natural here? Circle **A**, **B**, or **Both OK**.*

1. **Texting a friend:** A "I can't figure it out 😭" · B "I am unable to determine the solution."	A · B · Both
2. **A formal complaint letter to the city:** A "Hope you guys can sort this out!" · B "I request that the city resolve this issue."	A · B · Both
3. **In a meeting with your boss:** A "I came up with a new schedule." · B "I developed a new schedule."	A · B · Both
4. **Job interview:** A "When I have a problem, I don't give up. I figure it out." · B "When I encounter problems, I do not discontinue my efforts."	A · B · Both
5. **Chatting with a neighbor:** A "Did you sort out the parking thing?" · B "Did you resolve the parking matter?"	A · B · Both

🔎 **Slang Spotter:** A British coworker fixes the printer and says, *"Sorted!"* It means "It's fixed / done." It's **British and casual**. Understand it — but in the U.S., say *"All set!"* or *"It's fixed!"*

EXERCISE 7 Talk to Your Partner

Answer, then ask one follow-up question

*You can talk about your real life **or** the "or" option. Use at least 2 verbs in each answer.*

1. What is something you **figured out** recently — a new app, a recipe, a bus route? How did you figure it out?
2. Have you ever **given up** a habit (coffee, sugar, social media)? Was it hard? — or: What habit do many people try to give up? Why is it hard?
3. Tell your partner about a time you had to **start over** — a document, a recipe, a game, a plan. — or: invent a funny story.
4. When you have a problem with a bill or an appointment, how do you **sort it out**? Call, email, or go in person?

Follow-up questions: *What happened next? · How long did it take? · Did anyone help you? · Would you do it differently?*

EXERCISE 8 Agree or Disagree? Group Talk

Groups of 3–4 · one Reporter shares with the class

Statement	Our group: Agree / Disagree / It depends
1. "You should **never give up**."	
2. "It's better to call than to email when you need to **sort out** a problem."	
3. "**Starting over** can be a good thing."	
4. "People **come up with** better ideas in a group than alone."	

I agree, because... · I'm not sure. It depends on... · I see your point, but... · For example, one time I...

EXERCISE 9 Quick Write: Don't Give Up!

5 minutes · 3–5 sentences

*Your friend texts you: "I want to quit. It's too hard." (learning to drive, a new job, an English class — you choose). Write your reply. Use 2 verbs **naturally** — don't force them!*

One True Sentence: Write one true sentence about your life with one verb from today.